Never one to give up, and rather like in Faiz's famous Partition poem, Bhagat Singh must have at this stage gritted his teeth and chastened himself with the words, '*Chale chalo keh woh manzil abhi nahin aayi*,' (Walk on, walk on, fellow traveller, for our destiny still lies ahead), because for him the leadership vacuum created an opportunity not to be missed. He was barely out of his teens then. And here he was proposing a new brand of politics, one which was the very antithesis of Gandhian satyagraha. A muscular revolutionary resistance against the imperialist Raj as opposed to Gandhi's passive non-cooperation was going to have to be the way forward. Bhagat Singh's politics was to stand for revolutionary violence, whereas Gandhi stood for non-revolutionary non-violence. In the popular mind, these positions came to be seen as two polar opposites. They predominate in the popular narrative of how the battle for Indian Independence was fought. The two traditions are two rival approaches in pre-independent India's quest for freedom. They incorporate contrasting strategies of resistance. The popular notion, however, is a gross simplification of the truth. And, here is why.

It is certainly true that Gandhi consciously stood for non-violence, but for him non-violence was a fetish. Bhagat Singh and his fellow revolutionaries took a much more practical, sophisticated and nuanced approach. While Gandhi drew from Indian mysticism, Bhagat Singh fervently rejected such unrealism, choosing instead to draw from a far wider range of sources. True it was that he sought inspiration from Indian revolutionaries such as Guru Gobind Singh and Shivaji, but he also learnt from Lafayette, Garibaldi and George Washington. In fact, the establishment of Naujawan Bharat Sabha, to bring Punjab's youth under one socialist non-religious banner, was inspired by Giuseppe Mazzini's Young Italy Movement in 1831. He realized that the foreign yoke of colonial oppression could not be lifted by turning the other cheek. Gandhi, of course, chose not to see this and strongly disapproved of Bhagat Singh's errant ways. When the young revolutionaries had the temerity to deviate from Gandhi's chosen path, he refused them support at all costs and thereby curried favour with the British.